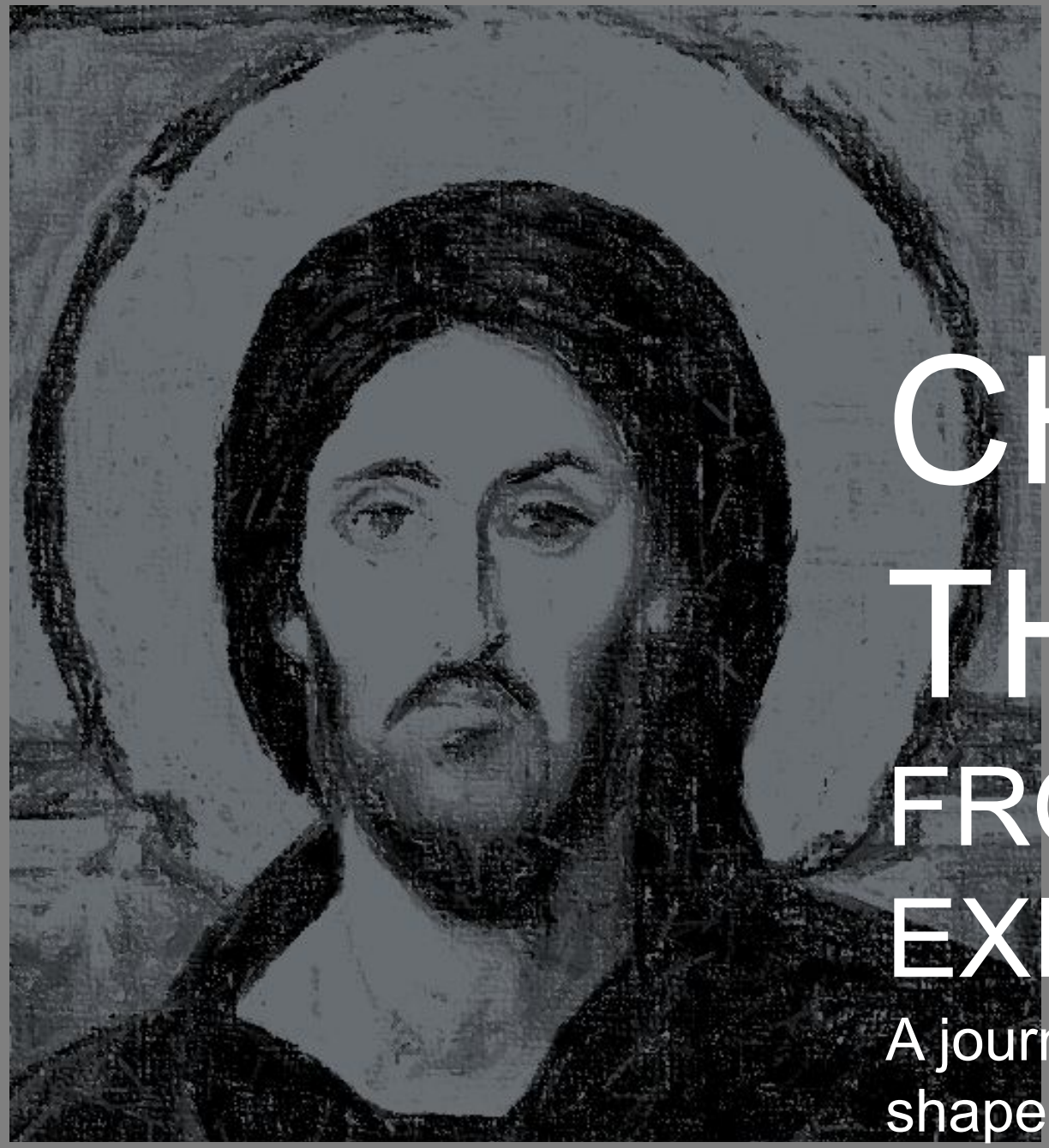


CHRISTIAN THOUGHT:

FROM LOGOS TO EXISTENTIALISM

A journey through 2000 years of ideas that shaped the West

WHY STUDY CHRISTIAN THOUGHT?

Understanding the intellectual foundations of Western civilization.

- It is not just a theological exercise, but a foray into the history of ideas.
- Christianity was not just a religion, but a complete philosophical system that answered the great questions (metaphysics, ethics, epistemology).
- Christian thought synthesized Greek philosophy and Judaic revelation, creating a new cultural paradigm.

Recensământul Populației și Locuințelor 2024

Date finale

www.statistica.gov.md

Populația cu reședință obișnuită

la 8 aprilie 2024 - **2 409,2 mii persoane**

Populația după religia declarată

	2024		2014	
Ortodoxă	2 271 105	94,3%	2 350 041	90,5%
Baptistă	26 226	1,1%	24 426	0,9%
Martorii lui Iehova	16 505	0,7%	16 776	0,6%
Penticostală	12 606	0,5%	9 504	0,4%
Adventistă	6 982	0,3%	8 339	0,3%
Creștină după Evanghelie	6 364	0,3%	4 655	0,2%
Staroveri	4 053	0,2%	2 447	0,1%
Islam	3 138	0,1%	1 798	0,1%
Catolică	2 586	0,1%	2 527	0,1%
Alte religii	4 720	0,2%	3 277	0,1%
Liber cugetător	440	0,0%	17	0,0%
Agnostic	2 117	0,1%	419	0,0%
Ateu	14 211	0,6%	5 364	0,2%
Fără religie	20 051	0,8%	286	0,0%
Nu au declarat	18 103	0,8%	165 895	6,4%

Notă: Fără localitățile din partea stângă a Nistrului și mun. Bender.

THE GREAT SHIFT: CHRISTIANITY VS. ANCIENT GREEK PHILOSOPHY

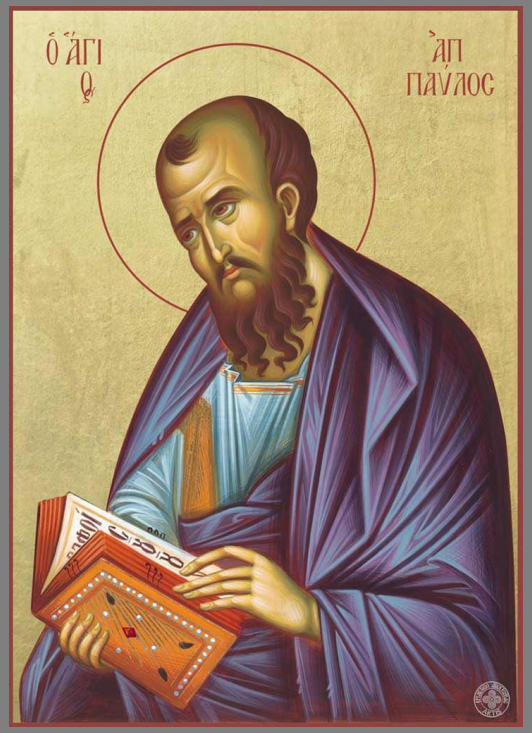
What new things did Christianity bring to the stage of ideas?

Concept	Ancient Greek Philosophy	Christian Thought (Novelty)
Time & History	Cyclical (eternal return). History has no final purpose.	Linear. It has a beginning (Creation), a center (Incarnation), and an end (Eschaton/Judgment). History has meaning.
God	Often impersonal (Unmoved Mover in Aristotle, The One in Plotinus).	Personal (Theism). A God who loves (Agape) and gets involved in history.
Man	Value given by reason or citizenship (exclusive).	Imago Dei (Image of God). Intrinsic, universal value, regardless of social status (basis of human rights).
Matter/Body	Often seen as inferior or a "prison" of the soul (Platonism).	Good, because it is created by God. The Incarnation validates it supremely.
Ethics	Based on knowledge and civic virtue.	Based on love (caritas/agape) and obedience to the divine will.

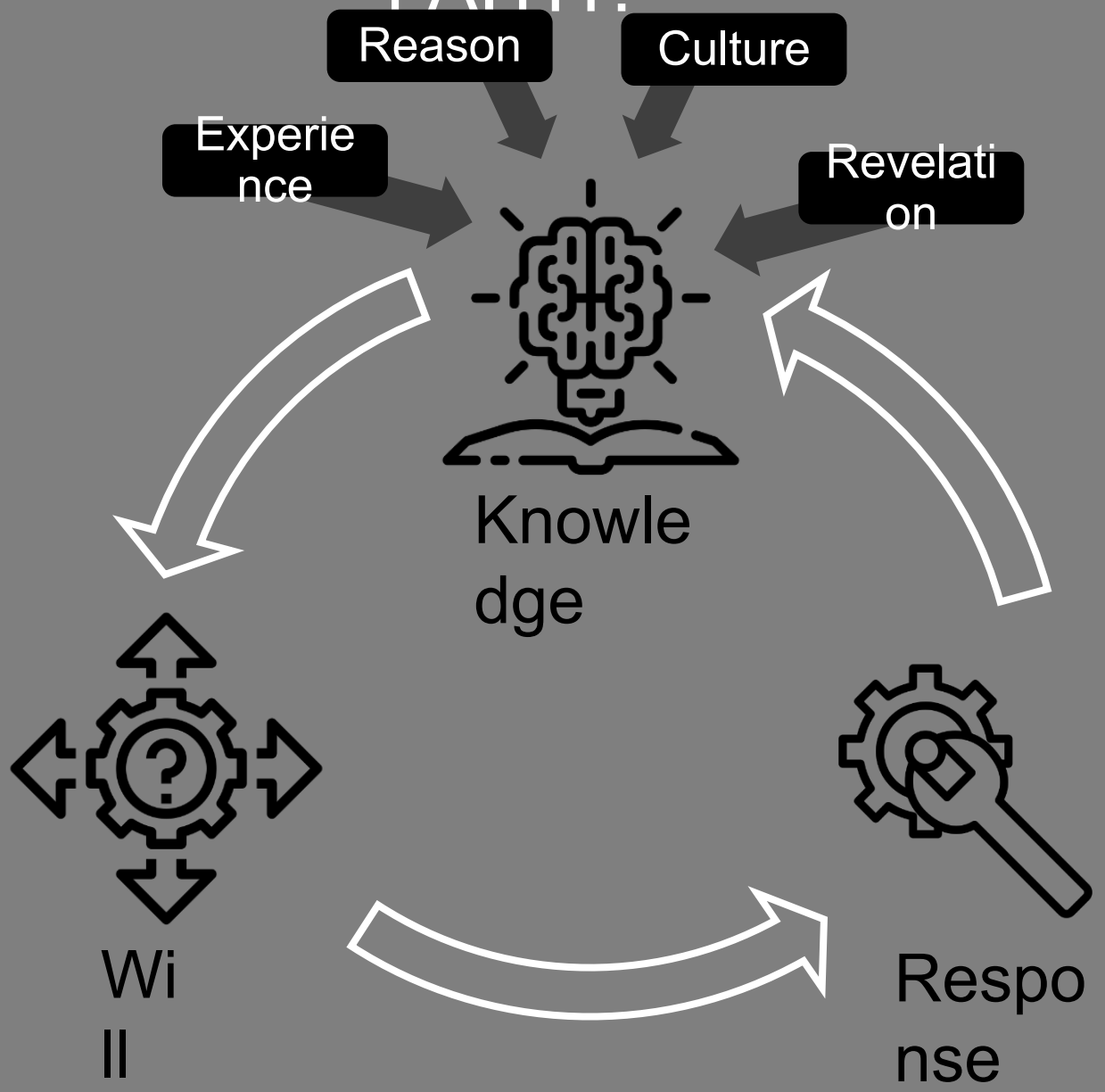
THE FIGURE WITHOUT WHOM THE CHRISTIAN MESSAGE WOULD NOT EXIST.

1 Corinthians 15:14

And if Christ be not risen, then is our preaching vain, and your faith is also vain.



WHAT IS FAITH?



STAGE I: APOLOGETICS (1ST-3RD CENTURIES) - "FAITH SEEKING UNDERSTANDING“

The period of defending Christianity against persecution and pagan accusations.

- Context: Christianity was a minority, illegal sect.
- Central idea: Christianity is not an irrational superstition, but the true philosophy.

KEY FIGURES:

Justin Martyr (c. 100–165)

Argued that "seeds of the Logos" (truth) are also found in Greek philosophy (e.g., Socrates), but the complete Logos is Jesus Christ.

Tertullian (c. 155–220)

More skeptical of philosophy.

- *"What has Athens (philosophy) to do with Jerusalem (faith)?"*
- *"The Blood of the Martyrs is the Seed of the Church"*

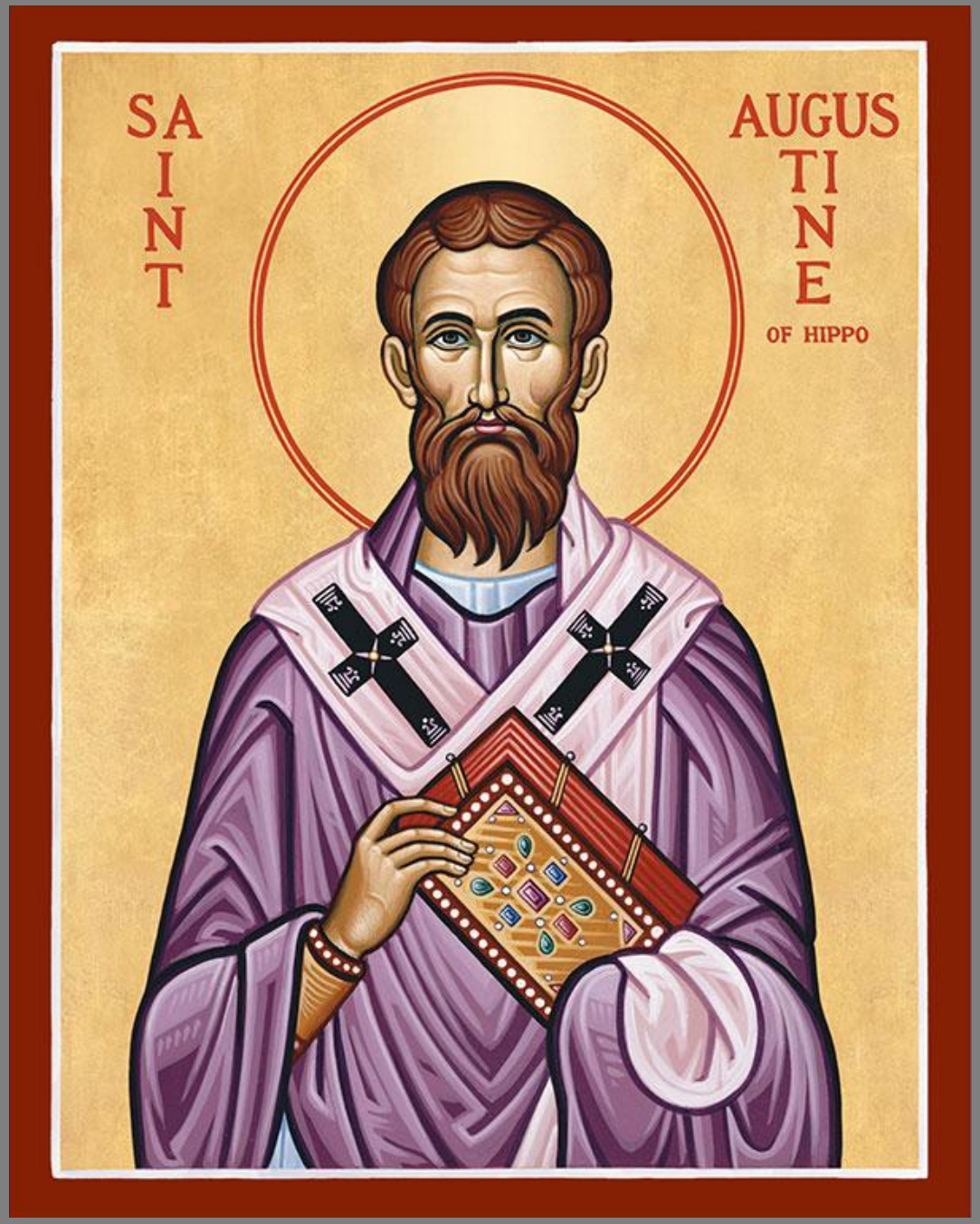
Coined Latin Theological Terms:

- Trinity (*trinitas*)
- Substance (*substantia*) and Person (*persona*)
- Substance (*substantia*) and Person (*persona*)

STAGE II: PATRISTICS (4TH-8TH CENTURIES) - AGE OF THE CHURCH FATHERS

Golden age of formulating dogmas (setting the "rules of the game").

- Context: Christianity becomes an accepted religion, then official. Major controversies appear (who exactly is Jesus?).
- Central ideas: Formulation of the doctrine of the Trinity and the nature of Christ.



Augustine of Hippo (354–430)

Most influential thinker for the West for 1000 years.

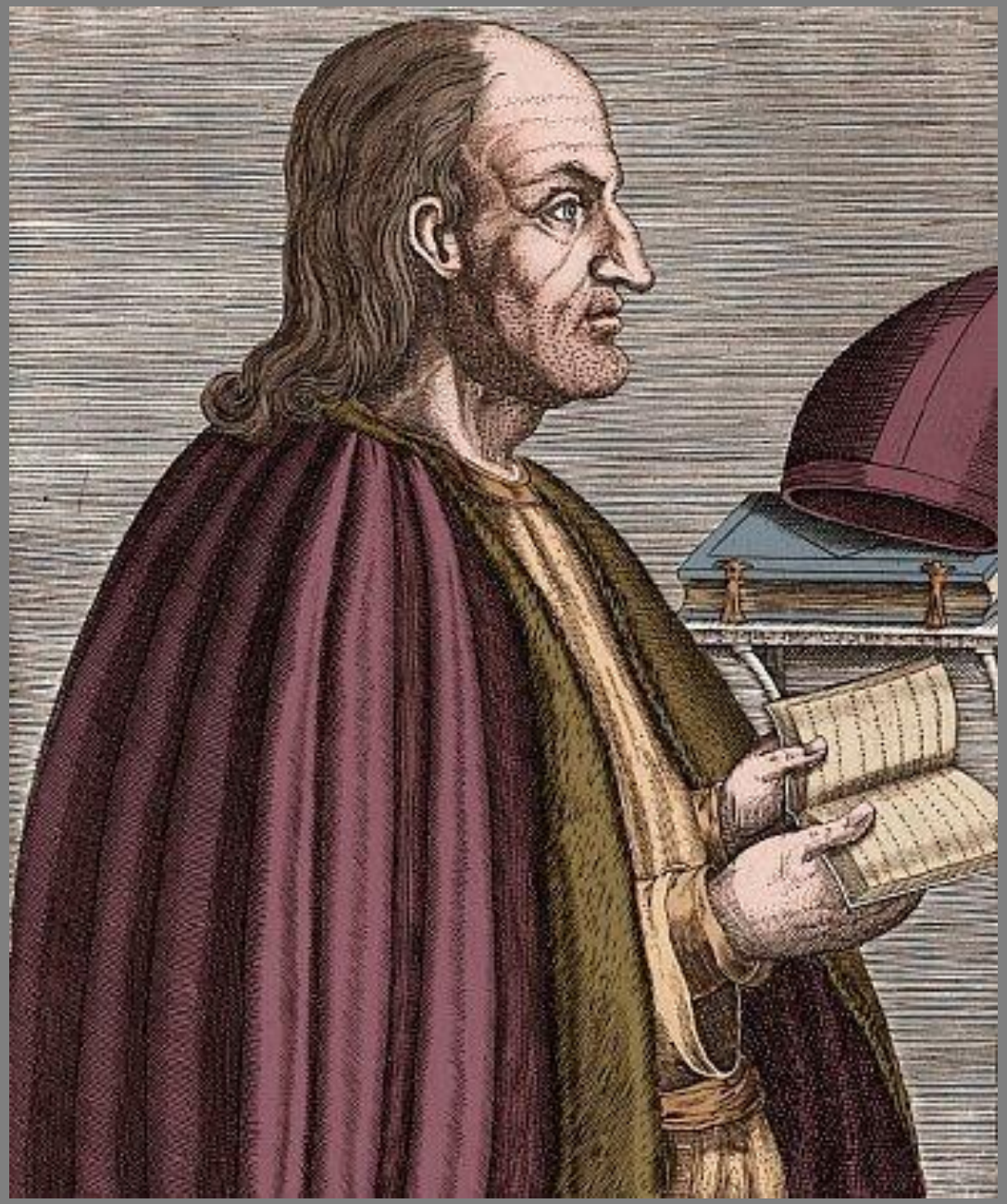
Key Augustinian ideas:

- *Original Sin:* Man is fundamentally broken and needs divine grace, cannot save himself (unlike Greek optimism).
- *Credo ut intelligam:* "I believe so that I may understand." Faith is a precondition for higher knowledge.
- *City of God:* First major philosophy of history. History is a struggle between the "City of

STAGE III: SCHOLASTICISM (11TH-14TH CENTURIES) - THE GREAT MEDIEVAL SYNTHESIS

Period of universities and cathedrals. Attempt to perfectly harmonize faith with reason.

- Context: Rediscovery of the complete works of Aristotle (via Arab sources). The University appears.
- Central idea: Natural reason and divine Revelation cannot contradict each other, because both come from God.



KEY FIGURES:

Anselm of Canterbury (1033–1109): *Ontological argument* – attempt to prove God's existence through pure logic alone.

ONTOLOGICAL ARGUMENT

1. By definition, God is a being than which none greater can be imagined.
2. A being that necessarily exists in reality is greater than a being that does not necessarily exist.
3. Thus, by definition, if God exists as an idea in the mind but does not necessarily exist in reality, then we can imagine something that is greater than God.
4. But we cannot imagine something that is greater than God.
5. Thus, if God exists in the mind as an idea, then God necessarily exists in reality.
6. God exists in the mind as an idea.

Thomas Aquinas (1225–1274)
"Prince of Scholasticism".

- Achieved the massive synthesis between Aristotle and Christianity.
- *Main thesis:* "Grace does not destroy nature but perfects it". We can know much about the world and ethics through reason alone, but for salvation, we need revelation.
- *The Five Ways:* Cosmological arguments for the existence of God.

THE FIVE WAYS OF THOMAS AQUINAS: DEMONSTRATING GOD'S EXISTENCE

1. The Argument from Motion (The Unmoved Mover)

- Observation: We observe that things in the world are in motion (change, action, becoming).
- Principle: Everything that is in motion must be put into motion by something else. Nothing can move itself. (To move implies a change from potentiality to actuality, and this change requires an actualizer.)
- Reasoning: If there is an infinite regress of movers, then there would be no *first* mover to initiate the chain, and thus no subsequent motion. Therefore, there must be a First Mover, itself unmoved, that starts all motion.

2 The Argument from Efficient Cause (The Uncaused First Cause)

- Observation: We observe that everything has an efficient cause (a producer or originator). Nothing causes itself.
- Principle: In the world of sense, we find an order of efficient causes.
- Reasoning: It is impossible for a thing to be its own efficient cause, as it would have to exist before itself, which is absurd. If there were an infinite regress of efficient causes, there would be no *first* cause, and thus no subsequent causes or effects. Therefore, there must be a First Efficient Cause, itself uncaused.

3 The Argument from Contingency (The Necessary Being)

- Observation: We observe that things in the world are contingent; they are born and they die, they begin to exist and cease to exist. They "might or might not be."
- Principle: If everything were contingent, then at some point in the past, there would have been nothing (because everything contingent eventually ceases to exist). If there was once nothing, then nothing could have come into existence.
- Reasoning: But things *do* exist. Therefore, there must be something that is not contingent, but necessary. This Necessary Being exists by its own nature and causes the existence of all contingent beings.
- Conclusion: This Necessary Being is what we call God.

4 The Argument from Gradation of Being (The Supreme Perfect Being)

- Observation: We observe that there are different degrees of perfection in things (e.g., some things are "better," "truer," "nobler" than others). We speak of things being more or less good, more or less beautiful, etc.
- Principle: These "more" and "less" qualities imply a standard or a maximum. For anything to be "more" or "less" of a quality, there must be something that is *most* that quality, which serves as the ultimate standard.
- Reasoning: Just as a fire is the hottest thing and causes other things to be hot, there must be something that is the cause of all being, goodness, and every other perfection.
- Conclusion: This ultimate cause of all perfection, which is

5 The Argument from Design or Governance (The Grand Designer / Teleological Argument)

- Observation: We observe that natural bodies, even those without intelligence (like planets or plants), act for an end or purpose. They exhibit purposeful behavior and operate according to fixed laws, tending toward the best result.
- Principle: Things that lack intelligence cannot move toward an end unless they are directed by something intelligent, just as an arrow is directed by an archer.
- Reasoning: The order and purpose we see in the natural world cannot be due to chance. There must be an intelligent being that directs all natural things to their ends.
- Conclusion: This intelligent being, which directs all natural things

STAGE IV: REFORMATION AND COUNTER-REFORMATION (16TH CENTURY)
CRISIS OF AUTHORITY

A major rupture that emphasizes the individual and the sacred text, not the institution.

- Context: Institutional corruption, Renaissance (return to sources - *ad fontes*).
- Central ideas: Salvation is a personal, direct matter between the individual and God, without necessary institutional mediators.

KEY FIGURES:

Martin Luther (1483–1546)

- *Sola Fide* (by faith alone), *Sola Scriptura* (scripture alone).
- Challenging the authority of the Pope and church tradition as being equal to the Bible.

John Calvin (1509–1564)

- Emphasis on God's absolute sovereignty and predestination. Influenced the work ethic in early capitalism (Max Weber's thesis).

STAGE V: MODERNITY AND CONTEMPORARY ERA (17TH CENTURY - PRESENT)

Response to the challenges of science, rationalism, and secularization.

- Challenge: The Enlightenment encouraged people to rely on logic and facts, which often made them question traditional religious faith.

KEY RESPONSES

Blaise Pascal (1623-1662):

"The heart has its reasons which reason knows nothing of".
Pascal's Wager. A defense of faith against cold rationalism.

PASCAL'S WAGER: A GAMBLE FOR THE SOUL

The Premise: You Must Choose.

Pascal asserts that you cannot avoid the choice. You either live as if God exists (and try to believe) or you live as if God does not exist (and don't believe). There's no neutral ground, no opting out of the "game." "You must wager. It is not optional.“

The Two Main Choices (The Wager):

A) Believe in God.

B) Do Not Believe in God.

The Four Possible Outcomes (The Payoffs):

Scenario 1: You believe in God, AND God *does* exist.

Outcome: You gain everything (eternal life, infinite happiness, salvation). This is an infinite gain.

Scenario 2: You believe in God, AND God *does not* exist.

Outcome: You lose very little (some earthly pleasures, time spent in prayer, etc.). This is a finite loss.

PASCAL'S WAGER

A PRAGAMTIC ARGUMENT FOR BELIEF

YOUR WAGER	REALITY: A. GOD EXISTS (TRUE)	REALITY: B. GOD DO SN'T EXISST (FALSE)
1. BELIEVE IN GOD	**INFINITE GAIN** (ETERNAL LIFE)	**FINITE LOSS** (EARTHLY PLEASURES)
2. DON'T BELIEVE IN GOD	**INFINITE LOSS** (ETERNAL DAMNATION)	**FINITE GAIN** (EARTHLY FREEDOM)

THE RATIONAL CHOICE: WAGER ON GOD (MAXIMIZE POTENTIAL GAIN)

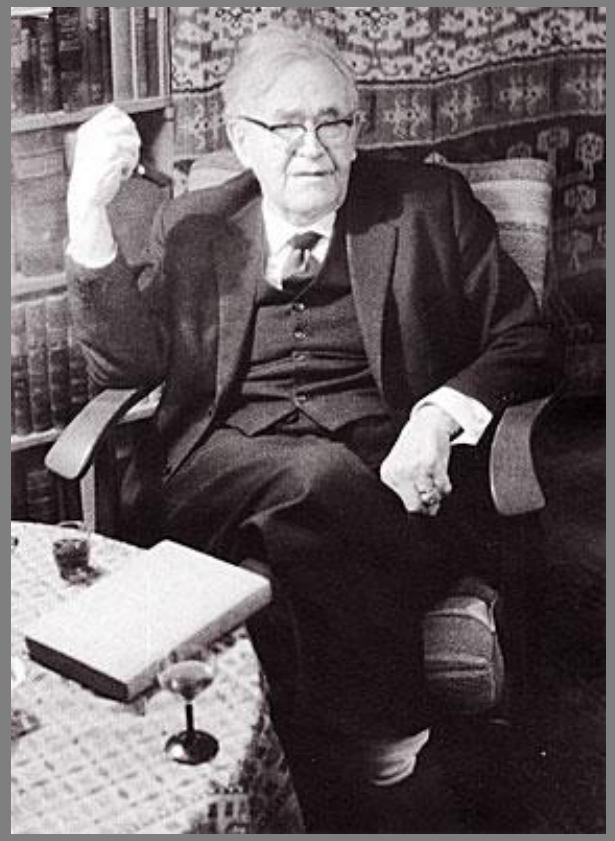
Søren Kierkegaard (1813-1855)

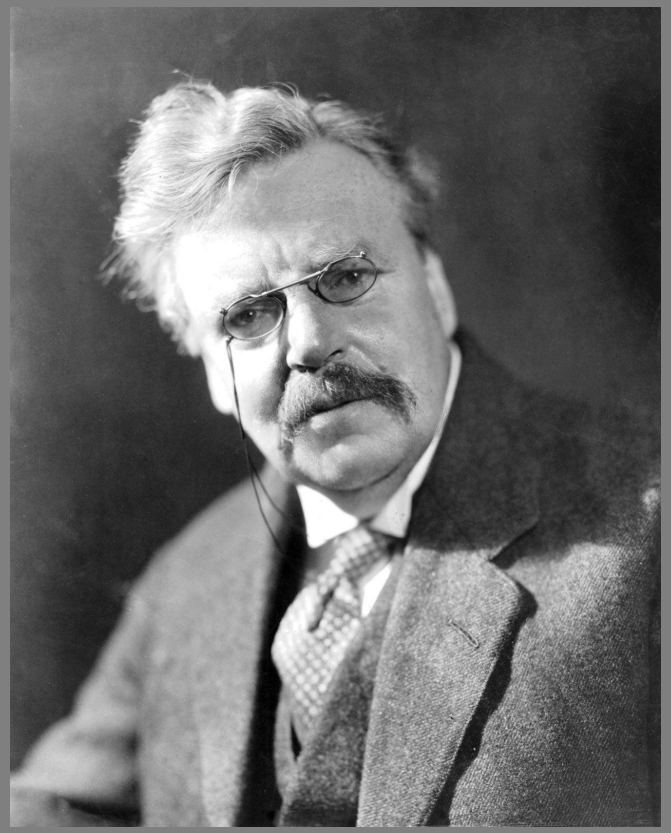
Father of existentialism.

- Faith is not a rational system (as in Hegel), but a paradoxical "leap", a subjective passion in the face of existential anxiety.

20th Century

- *Karl Barth:* Neo-orthodoxy – rejection of liberal theology that had transformed Christianity into mere humanistic ethics.
- *C.S. Lewis / G.K. Chesterton:* Modern apologetics – using literature and reason to defend Christianity to the general public.





IMPACT ON WESTERN CIVILIZATION

1. Human Dignity: The concept of *Imago Dei* is the direct ancestor of universal human rights. Without it, human value was tied to social utility (as in ancient Rome).

2. Modern Science: Paradoxically, it appeared in a Christian environment. The idea that the universe is created by a rational God ("Logos") means the universe is ordered, predictable, and can be studied.

3. Universities: They are a direct invention of the medieval Church (Bologna, Paris, Oxford).

4. Institutionalized Charity: The idea of caring for the weak